

Lee's response

Throughout the day on May 8, Confederate cavalrymen fought fierce delaying actions, slowed the Union advance, and allowed Anderson's soldiers, hastening down a parallel route, to choose their ground. They arrived at the village minutes ahead of the Union vanguard, and General Jeb Stuart deployed them across the high ground to the west, where they were soon repulsing one piecemeal attack after another. As darkness fell, more and more units were fed into the ensuing fight, each stumbling into position along a lengthening front. As Grant had feared, Lee had his troops dig in.

By morning, a forbidding arc of Confederate earthworks, fronted by abatis (felled treetops) and sharpened stakes, was snaking through the woods and fields. At a 1-mile (1.6-km) bulge in the line, known as the Mule Shoe Salient by the Confederates, these works were dauntingly impressive—packed-earth breastworks framed by log revetments (retaining walls), rifle ports topped by shielding head logs, and stout traverses (intercepting embankments) jutting rearward to protect the defenders against flanking fire or crossfire. However, because the position had been hastily sited in the dark, for all its defenses it had a weakness: a breach by Grant could divide Lee's army.

30,000

The casualty total of the two armies at Spotsylvania Court House. Although the Union losses (18,000 killed and wounded) were larger, Lee's much smaller force suffered more heavily in proportion.